

Right of Reply by Bangladesh to Myanmar's statement delivered at the 75th session of UNGA

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Mr. President,

Bangladesh is taking the floor in exercise of its right to reply in respect of the statement made by Myanmar's Union Minister for the office of the State Counsellor this morning.

We were outraged to witness another blatant demonstration of falsehoods and fabrications by Myanmar. Myanmar's statement on the developments in Rakhine, particularly on the bilateral repatriation process, is not only concocted, but is grossly misleading.

Bangladesh strongly rejects such baseless accusation, falsification, and misrepresentation of facts.

We emphatically reject the allegations made that Bangladesh is harbouring terrorists from Myanmar. Bangladesh, under the leadership of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina maintains a zero-tolerance policy to terrorism, terrorist financing and other drivers of terrorism. We do not allow our territory to be used by any terrorist entities under any pretext. Our track record in countering terrorism with due respect to human rights has earned us appreciation in all forum.

Myanmar, on the other hand, needs to look at its own mirror. Myanmar's track record of inhumane treatment of their ethnic minorities is not new. It is their state policy; a deliberate policy of exclusion and persecution of their own people that instigate insurgency, and turns the country into a breeding ground for all kinds of organized crimes.

Rather, it was Bangladesh who has been repeatedly offering meaningful security cooperation. However, without showing any interest, Myanmar continues resorting to unsubstantiated blame game. As I speak now, a deadly conflict is going on in Rakhine State despite the Global Call for Ceasefire by the UN Secretary General. Myanmar has deliberately kept the Rakhine state out of the purview of the ceasefire in order to implement its genocidal campaign against its own people, the Rohingyas. Bangladesh was one of the first countries to join the ceasefire call.

Mr. President,

Now let me turn to the issue of repatriation. First of all, the Rohingya issue is not a bilateral issue. It's Myanmar's internal problem. As my Prime Minister reiterated in this august Assembly earlier this week, the Rohingya problem has originated in Myanmar and its solution lies in Myanmar. By virtue of being Myanmar's neighbor, we have become victims of their internal policies and actions resulting in over a million of their nationals taking shelter in our land.

We have been persistently calling for resolving this protracted problem through dialogue. It was in good faith that we entered into bilateral agreements with Myanmar. But it appears that Myanmar has no intention to live up its side of the agreement yet, and instead resort to distorting history and facts to justify their genocidal acts. The unsubstantiated claims and undue accusations made against Bangladesh today by Myanmar's esteemed Minister was done to avoid their own obligations for the repatriation and reintegration of the forcibly displaced Rohingya in safety and dignity. Obviously, the conditions are so bad that not a single Rohingya has agreed to return voluntarily. The international community and UN agencies are witness to that. We call upon Myanmar to open up Rakhine State to international organizations, the UN, media and member states to observe the situation on the ground.

It is not unknown to anyone in this forum, after the extensive hearing at the international court of justice in December 2019, what caused the forced displacement of Rohingya from Myanmar. During the hearing Myanmar's efforts to downplay the magnitude of the atrocities were witnessed by the whole world. The world saw in utmost dismay how Myanmar State Councilor refrained herself from referring to these persecuted people as Rohingyas except on one occasion.

Today 1.1 million Rohingyas are sheltered in Bangladesh. These Myanmar nationals fled for their lives in the face of the carnage unleashed by the Myanmar junta in August 2017 in the name of 'clearance operations'. The whole world watched in utter horror as tens of thousands of innocent Rohingyas, with a large majority of them being women and children, fled burning homes and villages, rape, and murder.

What did Bangladesh do? We opened our border and saved lives. We acted in good faith. In a gesture of good neighborliness negotiated bilateral arrangements for return. We have tried to arrange repatriation process under those arrangements. Yet, not a single Rohingya agreed to go back. In the backdrop of the Myanmar's persistent claim that they were ready to receive Rohingyas, we agreed to facilitate repatriation on two occasions: in November 2018 and August 2019. Unfortunately, no one, cleared by Myanmar agreed to return on apprehension

of further persecution and lack of any visible action on the part of Myanmar to address their core concern.

The Myanmar Minister claimed that 350 Rohingyas have returned to Myanmar on their own volition. 350 out of 1.1 million in 3 years? Even if we are to accept the distinguished Minister's statement, we would like to know- who are these 350 persons? Where are they now? Are they living in safety and security in their own homes? Without any concrete evidence of their whereabouts, a mere 350 persons out of around 1.1 million does not testify to any improvement of the ground reality in Rakhine. Clearly that has not convinced a single Rohingya sheltered in the camps to return.

Why? Because they do not trust Myanmar. They are afraid of their lives. They do not know what awaits them in Myanmar. Reports still come in every day of continued isolation, discrimination and clearance operations, obliterating villages; wiping out entire habitats, and even changing maps. Where do they return to?

We urge Myanmar to abandon its policy of lies and propaganda, and demonstrate genuine political will to take back their own nationals; in safety and security, to their homes. Myanmar needs to assure their people that when they return, they won't be killed again, raped again, tortured again. Myanmar should undertake visible actions, not just seek the attention of international community by making hollow calls to take back their citizens. Myanmar must address the real causes that are preventing the displaced Rohingya from going back voluntarily and not go on a charade of falsehoods and shifting the blame and onus on its neighbours. It is not Bangladesh's responsibility to keep bearing Myanmar's burden; again and again.

We urge Myanmar to stop these false accusations and instead demonstrate to the Rohingya people and the world that Myanmar will provide a safe space where Rohingyas are not subject to any form of violence, have proper homes, access to education, health and livelihood. We request the international community to help Myanmar to provide such facilities and Bangladesh stands ready to engage with Myanmar for the repatriation and rehabilitation of the Rohingya people. Myanmar needs to have genuine intent and political will to address these to earn respect internationally.

I thank you, Mr. President.